MODERN ENGLISH AUSTRALIA

Commas in relative clauses

Defining and non-defining relative clauses · B2 Name _____ Date _____

No commas: essential
The clause tells us which one. You can use **that**.
The students **who studied** passed.

Commas: extra
We already know which one. Never **that**; never leave the word out.
My mother**, who is 70,** still works.

A. Add commas where they are needed. Tick the sentences that are already correct.

1. My father who is 68 still plays tennis every week.
2. The people who live upstairs are very noisy.
3. Canberra which is the capital of Australia is smaller than Sydney.
4. I need a phone that has a better camera.
5. We visited the Sydney Opera House which opened in 1973.
6. Anyone who arrives late will have to wait outside.
7. Her latest novel which I finished last night is brilliant.
8. The car that was parked outside has gone.
9. Dr Lee whose lectures are always full is retiring this year.
10. Is there a shop near here that sells stamps?
11. They moved to Hobart where they opened a small bakery.
12. Students whose assignments are late will lose marks.

B. Each sentence has one mistake with commas or with that. Write it correctly.

1. My sister, that lives in Perth, is a nurse.

_____

2. The book, that I'm reading, is about Mars.

_____

3. Paris which I love is expensive.

_____

4. People, who smoke, pay more for insurance.

_____

5. Mr Tan, who teaches maths is leaving.

_____

6. This is Anna who I work with.

_____

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C. Complete with who, which, whose or where. Then finish each sentence so it is true for you.

Say your sentences to a partner. Pause at each comma.

	Sentence	My ending
1	My home town, _____ is in ..., is famous for ...	
2	My best friend, _____ I have known for ... years, is ...	
3	My favourite teacher, _____ lessons were never boring, taught me ...	
4	Last year I went to ..., _____ I tried ... for the first time.	
5	My phone, _____ I bought ... ago, is ...	
6	My mother, _____ is from ..., loves ...	
7	I grew up in ..., _____ is ... kilometres from here.	
8	My neighbour, _____ name is ..., is very ...	
9	I'd love to visit ..., _____ you can see ...	
10	My favourite singer, _____ songs I know by heart, is ...	

D. Write four sentences about your partner. Add extra information with commas.

Example: Yuki's home town, which is near Osaka, is famous for its castle.

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Answer key

A

1. My father, who is 68, still plays tennis every week.
2. ✓ Correct: no commas.
3. Canberra, which is the capital of Australia, is smaller than Sydney.
4. ✓ Correct: no commas.
5. We visited the Sydney Opera House, which opened in 1973.
6. ✓ Correct: no commas.
7. Her latest novel, which I finished last night, is brilliant.
8. ✓ Correct: no commas.
9. Dr Lee, whose lectures are always full, is retiring this year.
10. ✓ Correct: no commas.
11. They moved to Hobart, where they opened a small bakery.
12. ✓ Correct: no commas.

B

1. My sister, who lives in Perth, is a nurse.
2. The book that I'm reading is about Mars.
3. Paris, which I love, is expensive.
4. People who smoke pay more for insurance.
5. Mr Tan, who teaches maths, is leaving.
6. This is Anna, who I work with.

In 2 and 4, which or that are both possible, and in 2 the word can be left out. In 6, whom is also correct.

C

1. My home town, **which** is in ..., is famous for ...
2. My best friend, **who** I have known for ... years, is ...
3. My favourite teacher, **whose** lessons were never boring, taught me ...
4. Last year I went to ..., **where** I tried ... for the first time.
5. My phone, **which** I bought ... ago, is ...
6. My mother, **who** is from ..., loves ...
7. I grew up in ..., **which** is ... kilometres from here.
8. My neighbour, **whose** name is ..., is very ...
9. I'd love to visit ..., **where** you can see ...
10. My favourite singer, **whose** songs I know by heart, is ...

Students' own endings. Check for a comma before and after each clause. 2 can also be whom.